



DIY

Step 2: Set the zoom to maximum and click photos just as you would for any sort of panorama. Turn off digital zoom from the Settings menu in your camera so you don't lose any quality, and then zoom to the extreme end and start clicking photos from one end such as the left bottom of the view and slowly move to the right and then upwards. In short, cover the entire area in front of you. You don't have to make it a complete panorama for this.

Step 3: Download and install HD View from <http://tinyurl.com/9ymwlj>.

HD View is useful because loading a gigapixel image as large as the ones you've seen online will take forever, so software like this breaks that image into multiple smaller images at different qualities and sizes so that regular PCs can easily load them. There is no loss of quality and there's no way to make out the sliced images.

There is also a Photoshop plug-in developed by the community which lets you export panoramas directly from Photoshop into an HD View panorama. To be able to export the panorama to HD View, you also need a small add-on for Windows. It's called Windows Imaging Component and is available on Microsoft's site.

Step 4: Download the HD View making plug-in for Photoshop from <http://tinyurl.com/c35wgf>. Once installed, copy the plugin file and the hdmake.exe file from the Program Files\Microsoft Research\HD View Utilities folder to the Adobe Photoshop's plugin folder.

Step 5: Restart Photoshop, click on File > Automate > Photomerge. Choose the folder or photos that you've captured. This step will stitch together the images but will take a lot of time depending on the number of photos you have. You save the completed image by clicking on File > Save as and then selecting a format.

Step 6: To export the image for HD View, click on File > Export > HD View & Deep Zoom. Choose HD View as the Output and select an output folder. You can select image compression settings and the kind of panorama. In our case, we chose flat. Click OK when done.

The output will be opened in your browser but you can also upload this file or folder to your web page for others to be able to view it. They will require the HD View plugin to do so.

Using Microsoft's Image Composite Editor

If you need to fiddle with the colour parameters of the images that you've shot, then using Photoshop is required. If you feel that all your photographs have similar contrast, brightness and colours, then using Microsoft's Image Composite Editor is simple.

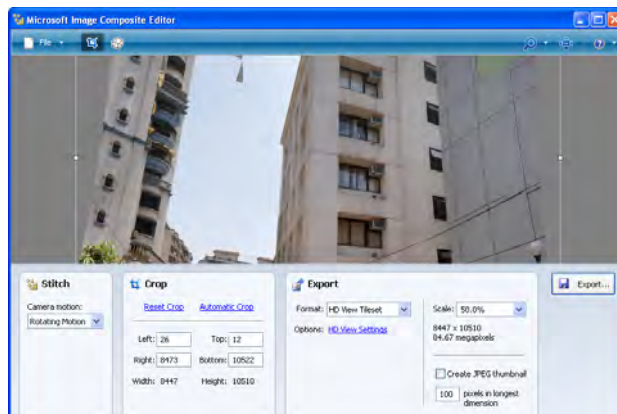
Microsoft Image Composite Editor (ICE) is available from <http://tinyurl.com/cs4bp3>. It's free for download and is useful for making any kind of panorama and just gigapixel images. You'll need .NET 3.5 framework for this application to work.

Once you have the software installed, drag and drop the images for the panorama from your Windows Explorer window to the Microsoft ICE window. The software will automatically align and join the photographs together. You can move the control points to crop the area you want to use for the gigapixel photo. If you want to get the best cropping, click the Autocrop link in the Crop section.

The next step is to export the final image as a photo which can be modified further in Photoshop. You can also export it as an HD View tileset. Click on the Format dropdown menu and choose the format. Finally, click the Export button.



Tokina, the Japanese lens manufacturer was made by ex-Nikon engineers



Microsoft ICE is an alternative image stitching software

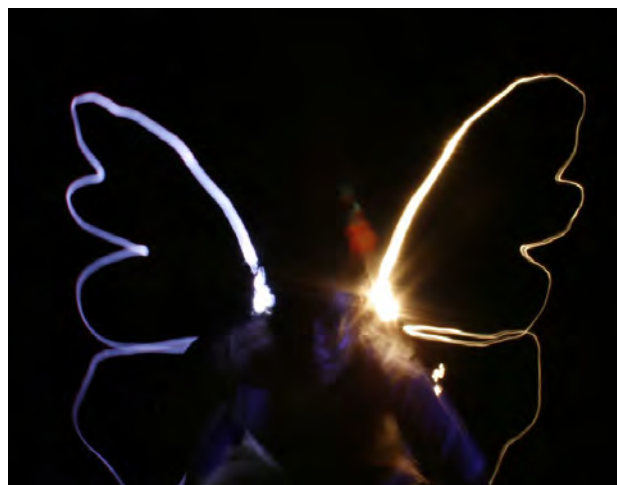
Light painting

Ever seen those photos of words written in darkness using light. It's one of the simplest things to try with the camera. All you need for this is a camera, a tripod, and a volunteer with a bright object — a torch or a candle. Light painting is done in the dark so you only see the bright lights in motion captured in a long exposure photo.

Step 1: Place camera on tripod, set the highest possible resolution and quality. Turn off the flash.

Step 2: Set the camera to manual mode. The aperture settings and ISO rating requires a little bit of fooling around before you can get the perfect shot.

Step 3: Set the shutter speed to as high as possible. Most cameras can do around 15 seconds, although DSLRs offer at least 30 seconds. Some cameras will let you keep the shutter open for as long as you hold the clicker.



An example of light painting

Step 4: Set a timer for the shutter release of 10 seconds and prepare to make a design.

Step 5: The shutter will stay open for 30 seconds, so in that time, make movements with the candle or torch facing the camera. Preview the image to see the results. You will have to do this a few times over before you get the hang of completing the light painting in the time period. Move the source of light at a steady pace to get an even painting.

If you want to write text, remember to use a mirror to figure out how to draw the text. Wearing dark clothes can help hide yourself in the image. Be in surroundings with no light present at all. ■

rossi.fernandes@thinkdigit.com